



MAGIC NUMBER

It is incredible but true—researchers have figured out the magic number of hours needed to turn someone into an expert. They say you need to practice for 10,000 solid hours, which works out at around three hours a day for ten years. There are countless examples of how putting in 10,000 hours of dedicated hard work will get you to the top of your game, whatever that game may be. However, as sports coaches such as American football legend Vince Lombardi (1913–1970) like to point out, only “perfect” practice makes perfect. If you practice incorrectly, you might make the same mistake over and over again. If you make mistakes every time you practice, you’re practicing mistakes as much as the right stuff. It’s tough to be consistently perfect, though. Once our brains have decided exactly how we need to move to serve a smash or score a goal, we don’t get it right every single time. Scientists think this is because our nervous systems are not made to do the same thing over and over. Instead, we adapt

to change. Small differences in the way the brain plans and calculates a movement cause a variation in the actual movement. While a champion athlete may strive to make every move consistent, most of us cannot move in the same way every time.

PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE

So, if you have 10,000 hours to spare you’re going to be a superstar, right? Maybe. But you’ll still need natural ability. Being in the right time and the right place helps, too, so you can take advantage of the opportunities that life presents you. Some people think luck plays a role, too. Practice makes perfect sense, though, if you want to get better at something. Good luck!